Qualitative Data Analysis and Reporting

What are we looking at? What can we claim? How do we show the path from data to interpretation?

What would you call this?

> **“I did not trust the new feedback tool until a colleague showed me how she used it with her own class.”**

Choose the strongest label for *the whole excerpt*. Then explain what your choice captures and misses.

Teacher training | **Peer modelling builds trust** | **Technology is good**

> Which words in the excerpt warrant your label? Would the label still work for another teacher’s account?

Five moves through today's lesson

01 Name the analytic unit: excerpt, code, category, topic, theme.

02 Make and challenge interpretations using the same short dataset.

03 Explore eight approaches through a method map, with thematic-analysis varieties and the practice passages included in the slides.

04 Choose an approach for a research scenario and defend the fit.

05 Explain the evidence for your interpretation and report the analytic route.

Five terms that do different work

Open the cards in any order. Which one is closest to the participant's words? Which one makes the largest interpretive claim?

▼ Data excerpt

The participant's or document's words selected for analysis; keep their context and source ID.

Example: "I asked a colleague before using it."

▼ Code

A concise analytic label attached to a meaningful segment.

Example: Seeking peer reassurance

▼ Category

A grouping of related codes; useful for organising material, but not automatically a theme.

Example: Sources of support

▼ Topic

What the material is about; often a useful heading, but it may only summarise a subject.

Example: Teacher training

▼ Theme

In interpretive thematic analysis, a patterned meaning organised around a central idea that answers the research question.

Example: Confidence grew through informal peer help when formal training fell short.

> Why might "teacher training" be a topic while "peer modelling builds trust" is a code?

Match the analytic role

Choose the role of each example. Check your choices, then compare one disputed answer with a partner.

“Training”	Your choice: _____
“Seeking informal help”	Your choice: _____
“Sources of support”	Your choice: _____
“Teachers’ confidence depended on informal peer validation when official guidance was thin”	Your choice: _____

Could the last sentence be defended from one quotation alone?

Three teachers, one question

Question: How do teachers build confidence when trying a new feedback tool?

T1

“The workshop showed the buttons, but I did not try it until Mei sat beside me and showed me her class example.”

T2

“I watched the recording twice. I still asked a colleague whether my feedback sounded right.”

T3

“The training gave me a usable routine. I tried it that afternoon and adjusted it after students responded.”

What is similar? What differs? Which account challenges an easy claim that peer support is always necessary?

Which code earns its place?

For T1’s “Mei sat beside me and showed me her class example”, choose a code that stays close to the action yet contributes to the question.

Technology | **Learning through peer modelling** | **Teachers always need colleagues**

Write another possible code and explain the difference.

Your notes: _____

What would you code in T2? Should T3 receive the same code? Why?

A topic names the area. A theme says something about it.

TOPIC HEADING

Teacher training

Tells us what the material concerns.

CANDIDATE INTERPRETIVE THEME

Confidence depends on usable guidance, whether formal or peer-led.

Connects T1–T3 around a central idea while leaving room for different routes.

Which further evidence would most strengthen the candidate theme?

- The number of times “training” appears
- More accounts showing how guidance was used and when it was insufficient
- A quotation from T1 repeated three times

> Does the claim overreach? How would T3 change your wording?

Keep each inference inspectable

Source excerpt
T1, T2, T3

Meaningful segments
What is happening?

Initial codes
Short labels

Categories or patterns
Compare cases

Candidate theme / account
What does it mean?

Finding
Claim + evidence + limits

Use this evidence trail to connect your interpretations to the data. Adapt the analytic steps to your chosen method. Reflexive thematic analysis is recursive; grounded theory, narrative analysis, discourse analysis and IPA make different analytic moves.

Which step involves the greatest interpretation, and how would you justify it using the data?

What helps the researcher think?

SALDAÑA (2021)

Coding as a heuristic

Codes can be revised and grouped into categories. Ask whether a proposed “theme” is only a topic heading.

MILES, HUBERMAN & SALDAÑA (2014)

Display the data

Matrices and networks make comparisons and exceptions visible; conclusions still need checking.

LEWINS & SILVER (2007); MORTELMANS (2024)

Use software purposefully

CAQDAS/NVivo can organise, retrieve and display material. The researcher chooses units, labels and interpretations.

> If software returns every excerpt coded “support”, what analytic question must you still answer?

References: *The Coding Manual*, ch. 1; *Qualitative Data Analysis*, chs. 4–5, 11; *Using Software in Qualitative Research*, chs. 1, 5–6; *Doing Qualitative Data Analysis with NVivo*.

Which kind of answer do you need?

Describe content

What kinds of messages or practices appear?

Content analysis

Interpret patterns

What shared meanings organise accounts?

Thematic / framework analysis

Explain a process

How does something develop through action?

Grounded theory

Study stories or language

How is experience narrated or a position constructed?

Narrative / discourse analysis

What data would each question require? Which choice would change your interview or document selection?

Explore qualitative analysis methods

Choose a method. Discuss its guiding questions using the practice text, then reveal the core features to check and refine your reasoning. Compare what each method attends to, how it analyses the material and what it produces.

Your question and intended finding

Choose a branch and explore further

Meaning and categories

Thematic analysis
Interpret patterns of meaning

Qualitative content analysis
Classify meaningful content

Framework analysis
Compare issues across cases

Stories and experience

Narrative analysis
Explore how stories are told

Interpretative phenomenological analysis
Explore lived meaning in each case

Language and power

Discourse analysis
Examine language in social action

Critical discourse analysis
Examine discourse, power and inequality

Processes and theory

Grounded theory
Develop an explanation of a process

Methods overlap: framework analysis relates to codebook approaches, and critical discourse analysis sits within discourse research. Use the purpose to identify connections and differences.

Which method fits the question?

Match all 10 scenarios to the best-fitting method for the stated aim. Methods may be used more than once. Explain your choice before checking; use “Mix order” to shuffle both the scenario list and each answer list for another round.

Case 1	How does AI policy wording position teachers as monitors and students as potential rule-breakers?	Your choice: _____
Case 2	How do six novice teachers make sense of being observed for the first time? Examine each lived experience closely before comparing cases.	Your choice: _____
Case 3	What kinds of AI use are permitted, discouraged or prohibited in 40 school policies? Develop and apply a category system.	Your choice: _____
Case 4	How do new teachers learn to negotiate assessment expectations? Use iterative interviews, comparisons and theoretically guided sampling to build a process theory.	Your choice: _____
Case 5	What shared meanings underpin teachers’ confidence in giving feedback? Interpret patterns across interviews around central organising ideas.	Your choice: _____

Choose two scenarios using the same method. What makes that method appropriate in both? Rewrite one research question so that another method would fit better.

Which method fits the question?

Match all 10 scenarios to the best-fitting method for the stated aim. Methods may be used more than once. Explain your choice before checking; use “Mix order” to shuffle both the scenario list and each answer list for another round.

Case 6	How do barriers and supports differ across five schools? Chart source-linked summaries in a school-by-issue matrix and compare within and across schools.	Your choice: _____
Case 7	How does a teacher tell the story of moving from industry into teaching? Preserve the sequence, turning points and narrative voice.	Your choice: _____
Case 8	How is belonging understood across migrant teachers’ accounts? Develop themes connecting acceptance, recognition and everyday exclusion.	Your choice: _____
Case 9	How does admission-policy language legitimise unequal access for migrant pupils? Connect textual choices to institutional inequality.	Your choice: _____
Case 10	How do two teachers narrate returning to work after a career break? Analyse each story’s chronology, turning points and self-presentation.	Your choice: _____

Choose two scenarios using the same method. What makes that method appropriate in both? Rewrite one research question so that another method would fit better.

Three readings of one excerpt

Read T1 again. Select a lens and predict what the analyst would look for.

> **T1 · “The workshop showed the buttons, but I did not try it until Mei sat beside me and showed me her class example.”**

Thematic | **Content** | **Discourse**

How does peer demonstration contribute to confidence across T1–T3?

Which lens best fits the original research question? What new question would make another lens preferable?

Make your analytic process transparent

1. Name the analytic approach and why it fits the question and data.
2. Describe the data, unit of analysis, analysts and their relevant positioning.
3. Explain the actual steps: coding or another procedure, comparison, revisions and exceptions.
4. Report how each finding is grounded in excerpts, context and a bounded claim.

> Use the target journal's instructions. APA JARS–Qual is a useful reporting prompt across qualitative traditions, not a replacement for method-specific reasoning.

APA JARS–Qual ↗

Take the lesson with you

Download the presentation, including the practice excerpts, guiding questions and method features.

Download lesson PDF

DEDC02 course materials →

Thematic analysis

Discuss these questions first

What shared meaning could connect several accounts? Which words support your interpretation?

How would you move from initial codes to a theme with a central organising idea? How does that differ from a topic heading?

How would the researcher’s role and quality criteria change across reflexive, codebook and coding-reliability approaches?

Support your answers with a lesson excerpt, then compare the features below.

Core features

Develops patterns of meaning across a dataset in relation to a research question.
Themes organise an analytic account; their meaning and development depend on the chosen approach.
Reflexive, codebook and coding-reliability approaches use different researcher roles and quality criteria.

A family of approaches for developing themes across qualitative material in relation to a research question. Specify the approach and what a theme means within it.

Likely output: A thematic map and an analytic account supported by extracts.

▼ **How do I do it?**

Choose a thematic-analysis approach and state your analytic assumptions.

Work through the material, code relevant meanings and develop themes suited to that approach.

Explain each theme using extracts, interpretation and the scope of the claim.

Methods reference: Braun & Clarke · Understanding TA ↗

Thematic analysis · practice and output

▼ What can an output look like?

Classroom illustration: workload, peer support and professional fulfilment are starting topics. A candidate theme could explore how student progress makes demanding work feel worthwhile. Test that idea in a fuller dataset.

Practice-text illustration · candidate ideas to examine

Extract	Possible code	Candidate analytic idea
“feeling overwhelmed”	Managing accumulated demands	Demands compete with creative practice
“all worthwhile”	Finding value in student learning	Student progress helps sustain commitment

Use the illustration to practise analytic judgement. Connect actual claims to the full material and its context.

Methods reference: Braun & Clarke · Understanding TA ↗

Thematic analysis · 1 · Compare three families of thematic analysis

▼ 1 · Compare three families of thematic analysis

▼ Reflexive thematic analysis

Situated interpretation

Researchers develop meaning through sustained engagement and reflexivity. Coding evolves; themes are analytic constructions.

In practice: Use analytic memos and dialogue to deepen interpretations. Explain how your positioning shaped decisions.

Quality focus: Coherent interpretation, developed themes and traceable evidence. Agreement statistics have a different analytic rationale.

▼ Codebook thematic analysis

A structured coding framework

An explicit coding framework organises analysis, often in applied team research. Templates or matrices can support consistent working procedures.

In practice: Define and revise codes, retain contextual notes and document how team decisions develop. Framework and template approaches can sit in this broad family.

Quality focus: A transparent framework and meaningful interpretation; explain how structure and revision serve the question.

▼ Coding-reliability thematic analysis

Reproducible coding decisions

A more standardised coding frame supports independent coders applying comparable rules. Reliability is part of the stated analytic logic.

In practice: Define code boundaries, train coders and explain how agreement and disagreements are assessed.

Quality focus: Clear operational decisions and justified reliability procedures, consistent with the underlying assumptions.

Choose an approach that fits the purpose, assumptions about knowledge and researcher role. Keep procedures and quality criteria coherent.

Braun & Clarke · Approaches and quality ↗

Thematic analysis · practice texts

▼ 2 · Explore analytic choices with the practice texts

Inductive/deductive concerns where concepts start; semantic/latent concerns the level of interpretation. These choices can combine within reflexive TA and should fit your view of knowledge.

Choose a practice text

Your choice: _____

> As a new teacher, I find that balancing my workload is challenging. While I enjoy the creativity involved in lesson planning, the constant demands of grading and administrative tasks often leave me feeling overwhelmed. I sometimes wish I had more support from my colleagues to share ideas and resources. Despite these challenges, seeing my students engage and learn makes it all worthwhile.

> Many students reported feeling overwhelmed by the amount of coursework assigned during the semester. They expressed that while online resources were helpful, they often struggled to manage their time effectively. Some students mentioned that group projects added to their stress, as coordinating schedules with peers proved challenging. However, a few students noted that collaborating online allowed them to share ideas more freely, which enhanced their learning experience.

Both practice texts are included in full in this slide. The teacher text is first-person; the student text summarises several experiences. Preserve that distinction when analysing them.

Examine candidate ideas in a fuller corpus. These short passages support practice in coding and interpretation; a dataset-wide theme needs broader evidence.

Braun & Clarke · Analytic orientations ↗

Thematic analysis · explain analytic choices

▼ 2 · Explore analytic choices with the practice texts

Inductive/deductive concerns where concepts start; semantic/latent concerns the level of interpretation. These choices can combine within reflexive TA and should fit your view of knowledge.

Where do concepts start?

- Inductive · start with material
- Deductive · start with concepts

What level of meaning?

- Semantic · explicit meanings
- Latent · underlying assumptions

Teacher account · inductive · semantic

Examine candidate ideas in a fuller corpus. These short passages support practice in coding and interpretation; a dataset-wide theme needs broader evidence.

▼ Explain your judgement, then compare

“Workload” can name a topic; “feeling overwhelmed by administration” can be a code; “student progress makes demanding work worthwhile” proposes an interpretive idea to test. What material would support or revise it?

Braun & Clarke · Analytic orientations ↗

Thematic analysis · compare analytic choices

Possible codes: enjoying creative planning; feeling overwhelmed by marking and administration; wanting collegial resource-sharing; valuing student learning. These stay close to explicit expressions.

Possible interpretation: student progress helps make sustained pressure feel worthwhile. Examine the implied relationship between commitment and demands, and record what further evidence could challenge it.

Start with the analytic concepts demands, resources and fulfilment. Map grading to demands, desired collegial support to resources, and student learning to fulfilment. Record material that the starting frame misses.

Use those starting concepts to ask how meaningful rewards might legitimise heavy demands. Treat this as a tentative interpretation; “worthwhile” provides a starting clue, with context and alternative readings still to examine.

Possible codes: managing coursework load; struggling with time; coordinating peers’ schedules; sharing ideas online. The passage reports experiences collectively, so keep that source form visible.

Possible interpretation: collaboration creates both opportunities and coordination demands. The contrast within the passage suggests an idea to examine in richer student accounts.

Start with demands, resources and learning opportunities. Classify scheduling as a demand, online resources as support, and idea-sharing as an opportunity; retain the different reported responses.

Ask how digital collaboration redistributes the work of organising learning. The scheduling difficulty and freer idea-sharing support competing readings; neither establishes students’ hidden intentions.

Thematic analysis · 3 · Work through reflexive thematic analysis

▼ 3 · Work through reflexive thematic analysis

Move back and forth through these six phases as interpretations develop. Re-reading, revising codes and reshaping themes are part of the work.

▼ 1 Read and revisit

Read the full material, note context and initial questions.

What surprised me, and how did my assumptions shape what I noticed?

▼ 2 Code meaningful material

Label features relevant to the question; keep extracts and context together.

Which exact words support my code? What other code could be plausible?

▼ 3 Build candidate patterns

Explore relationships among codes and a possible organising idea.

What meaning connects these codes? Which data differ?

▼ 4 Challenge the patterns

Review candidate themes against extracts and the whole corpus; revise their boundaries.

Is this idea supported across the relevant material? Where does it fail?

▼ 5 Clarify the theme claim

Define the central idea, scope and relation to other themes.

What does this theme explain, and how would I name it precisely?

▼ 6 Present the interpretation

Weave extracts into an analytic account; relate it to the question and relevant literature.

Can a reader follow the evidence for this interpretation and its limits?

> In reflexive TA, examine how your positioning shapes interpretation and use analytic dialogue to deepen it. If your aim is to assess coder agreement, explain the analytic logic of your chosen approach.

Braun & Clarke · Six phases of reflexive TA ↗

Qualitative content analysis

Discuss these questions first

What segment would you classify: a phrase, sentence or larger unit? What context must you retain?

What category definition and inclusion/exclusion rules would let you classify two similar excerpts consistently?

Would your categories start from the data or existing concepts? If you counted occurrences, what would the counts tell you and what context would you still need?

Support your answers with a lesson excerpt, then compare the features below.

Core features

Interprets meaningful content through an explicit category system.
Defines coding units, category boundaries and source-linked examples.
Conventional, directed and summative approaches differ in how categories or counts enter the analysis.

Systematic interpretation of text through a category system. Conventional analysis develops categories from the material; directed analysis starts with concepts; summative analysis interprets selected counts in context.

Likely output: A category table with definitions and source-linked examples; counts can support an appropriate question.

▼ **How do I do it?**

Define the question, material and unit to be coded.

Develop category definitions, inclusion rules and examples; pilot and revise them.

Classify the material, examine relationships and exceptions, and interpret categories in context.

Methods reference: Hsieh & Shannon (2005) ↗

Qualitative content analysis · practice and output

▼ Practice text for this lesson

> As a new teacher, I find that balancing my workload is challenging. While I enjoy the creativity involved in lesson planning, the constant demands of grading and administrative tasks often leave me feeling overwhelmed. I sometimes wish I had more support from my colleagues to share ideas and resources. Despite these challenges, seeing my students engage and learn makes it all worthwhile.

Use this short account to practise analytic judgement. Other fictional material in the example tables is labelled separately.

▼ What can an output look like?

In the teacher practice text, “grading” and “administrative tasks” can enter a work-demands category. Define the category boundary and keep the sentence context.

Practice-text illustration · a small category system

Category	Inclusion rule	Practice-text example
Work demands	Tasks requiring time and effort	Grading; administrative tasks
Desired support	Requested assistance or sharing	Ideas and resources from colleagues
Sources of fulfilment	Experiences described as rewarding	Students engage and learn

Use the illustration to practise analytic judgement. Connect actual claims to the full material and its context.

Methods reference: Hsieh & Shannon (2005) ↗

Framework analysis

Discuss these questions first

What would occupy a row and a column if you compared these teachers' accounts?

How could you summarise each cell while keeping a route back to the original excerpt?

What would comparing within one row and across a column reveal? Which exception or missing information needs checking?

Support your answers with a lesson excerpt, then compare the features below.

Core features

Charts source-linked summaries in a case-by-issue matrix.
Uses an analytic framework to organise systematic within-case and cross-case comparisons.
Retains access to case context while interpreting similarities, differences and exceptions.

A systematic approach using a case-by-issue matrix. Source-linked summaries support comparison while keeping case context accessible.

Likely output: A case-by-issue matrix linked to the original material and a comparative interpretation.

▼ **How do I do it?**

Become familiar with the material and develop an analytic framework.

Apply the framework and chart concise summaries with source references.

Compare within cases and across cases; return to full accounts to examine exceptions.

Methods reference: Gale et al. (2013) ↗

Framework analysis · practice and output

▼ Practice text for this lesson

> As a new teacher, I find that balancing my workload is challenging. While I enjoy the creativity involved in lesson planning, the constant demands of grading and administrative tasks often leave me feeling overwhelmed. I sometimes wish I had more support from my colleagues to share ideas and resources. Despite these challenges, seeing my students engage and learn makes it all worthwhile.

Use this short account to practise analytic judgement. Other fictional material in the example tables is labelled separately.

▼ What can an output look like?

An illustrative matrix might compare workload, support and fulfilment across teachers. Each cell summarises that teacher's account and records its source.

Fictional illustration · source IDs show where summaries belong

Case	Workload	Support
F1	Marking crowds out planning [F1:12]	Wants shared materials [F1:18]
F2	Planning time protected [F2:9]	Scheduled peer meetings [F2:21]
F3	Administration is heavy [F3:7]	Little time to meet [F3:14]

Use the illustration to practise analytic judgement. Connect actual claims to the full material and its context.

Methods reference: Gale et al. (2013) ↗

Narrative analysis

Discuss these questions first

Where does the account begin and end? What sequence and turning point does the teller construct?

How does the teller present themselves and address an audience? How does the telling shape the experience?

What would be lost if you split the story into isolated topic codes? How would you report its structure and meaning?

Support your answers with a lesson excerpt, then compare the features below.

Core features

Treats the story and its telling as an analytic focus.
Examines chronology, plot, turning points, voice and self-presentation in context.
Preserves connections within a narrated journey when developing an interpretation.

Analysis of stories as situated accounts: chronology, plot, turning points, voice and the circumstances of telling can shape meaning.

Likely output: A contextualised account or narrative reconstruction, supported by the teller's words.

▼ **How do I do it?**

Identify a story or narrative episode and preserve its surrounding context.

Examine sequence, characters, turning points and how the narrator presents events.

Interpret how the telling makes sense of experience; explain your chosen narrative approach.

Methods reference: Riessman · Narrative Methods ↗

Narrative analysis · practice and output

▼ Practice text for this lesson

> As a new teacher, I find that balancing my workload is challenging. While I enjoy the creativity involved in lesson planning, the constant demands of grading and administrative tasks often leave me feeling overwhelmed. I sometimes wish I had more support from my colleagues to share ideas and resources. Despite these challenges, seeing my students engage and learn makes it all worthwhile.

Use this short account to practise analytic judgement. Other fictional material in the example tables is labelled separately.

▼ What can an output look like?

The teacher practice paragraph is a short reflective account. A richer career story would be needed to explore transitions, turning points and changing identity in depth.

Fictional illustration · keep a story's sequence visible

Story movement	Narrated event	Possible meaning
Beginning	Leaves industry for teaching	Seeking purposeful work
Turning point	A first difficult lesson	Reconsidering competence
Later reflection	A colleague shares a strategy	Recasting help-seeking as learning

Use the illustration to practise analytic judgement. Connect actual claims to the full material and its context.

▼ Empirical study example

Karalis Noel (2021) · *Identity Tensions* ↗

Four interviews over a year underpin an account of one former teacher's schooling, preparation, work and departure. Notice how repeated interviews support attention to the sequence and telling of one person's story.

Using this study summary, explain how the material and analytic decisions fit the method. What further evidence would help you assess the interpretation?

Methods reference: Riessman · Narrative Methods ↗

Interpretative phenomenological analysis

Discuss these questions first

What significant lived experience is this person trying to make sense of?

How would you examine the person's words and meaning-making in depth before comparing other cases?

How does your interpretation engage with the participant's own interpretation? Which individual differences must remain visible in the final account?

Support your answers with a lesson excerpt, then compare the features below.

Core features

Explores how people make sense of significant lived experience.
Uses an idiographic focus: detailed analysis of each case precedes cross-case interpretation.
Recognises the analyst's interpretation of the participant's meaning-making and retains individual nuance.

An idiographic, interpretative approach exploring how a person makes sense of a significant lived experience. The researcher also interprets that meaning-making.

Likely output: A detailed experiential interpretation with case extracts and carefully developed cross-case themes.

▼ **How do I do it?**

Recruit people who have experienced the phenomenon and collect rich first-person accounts.

Read and interpret each case closely, attending to experiential meanings and your own assumptions.

Develop case themes, then examine convergence and divergence across cases.

Methods reference: Smith, Flowers & Larkin (2022) ↗

Interpretative phenomenological analysis · practice and output

▼ Practice text for this lesson

> As a new teacher, I find that balancing my workload is challenging. While I enjoy the creativity involved in lesson planning, the constant demands of grading and administrative tasks often leave me feeling overwhelmed. I sometimes wish I had more support from my colleagues to share ideas and resources. Despite these challenges, seeing my students engage and learn makes it all worthwhile.

Use this short account to practise analytic judgement. Other fictional material in the example tables is labelled separately.

▼ What can an output look like?

The teacher passage suggests possible interview prompts about feeling overwhelmed and finding fulfilment. Richer individual accounts are needed for an IPA study.

Fictional illustration · one case before comparison

First-person account	Exploratory note	Candidate experiential theme
“When the observer entered, I felt exposed.”	The gaze is experienced as personal exposure	Being seen as a test of professional worth
“Her nod let me breathe again.”	A small gesture changes the felt encounter	Seeking reassurance in an evaluative encounter

Use the illustration to practise analytic judgement. Connect actual claims to the full material and its context.

▼ Empirical study example

Gong, Xu & Ye (2025) · *Good or bad visits?* ↗

Eight teachers: two interviews and six written accounts. Each case was analysed before comparison. Notice the case-first sequence and the distinction between shared meanings and individual differences.

Using this study summary, explain how the material and analytic decisions fit the method. What further evidence would help you assess the interpretation?

Methods reference: Smith, Flowers & Larkin (2022) ↗

Discourse analysis

Discuss these questions first

What is the wording doing: justifying an action, claiming expertise or assigning a role?

Which contrasts, pronouns or descriptions position the speaker and other people? What textual evidence supports that reading?

How would the social or interactional context change your interpretation? How does this differ from classifying what was mentioned?

Support your answers with a lesson excerpt, then compare the features below.

Core features

Examines language as social action and the construction of meanings and positions.
Analyses specific linguistic choices in their social or interactional context.
Builds an evidence-based account of what language does, using a stated discourse approach.

A family of approaches examining how language works in context to construct meanings, identities and social action. Specify the tradition and textual focus.

Likely output: An evidence-linked account of how particular linguistic choices accomplish social work.

▼ **How do I do it?**

Choose an approach and locate texts or interactions in their production and use contexts.

Closely examine wording, pronouns, categories, positioning and rhetorical choices.

Link textual observations to what language accomplishes in that setting.

Methods reference: Gee · Discourse analysis ↗

Discourse analysis · practice and output

▼ Practice text for this lesson

> As a new teacher, I find that balancing my workload is challenging. While I enjoy the creativity involved in lesson planning, the constant demands of grading and administrative tasks often leave me feeling overwhelmed. I sometimes wish I had more support from my colleagues to share ideas and resources. Despite these challenges, seeing my students engage and learn makes it all worthwhile.

Use this short account to practise analytic judgement. Other fictional material in the example tables is labelled separately.

▼ What can an output look like?

The teacher's "I sometimes wish" makes a request indirectly; "all worthwhile" positions commitment. These are possible readings to examine in context.

Practice-text illustration · link words to a possible function

Wording	Textual observation	Possible social work
"I sometimes wish"	Tentative expression of need	Softening a request for support
"all worthwhile"	Positive evaluation after challenges	Presenting commitment despite pressure

Use the illustration to practise analytic judgement. Connect actual claims to the full material and its context.

▼ Empirical study example

Balán (2026) · critical discourse analysis · *The "skills-first" illusion* ↗

This empirical application takes a critical approach to 15 Microsoft communications. Open the critical discourse analysis branch to examine its focus.

Using this study summary, explain how the material and analytic decisions fit the method. What further evidence would help you assess the interpretation?

Methods reference: Gee · Discourse analysis ↗

Critical discourse analysis

Discuss these questions first

Whose interests or authority does the wording support? Whose perspective is absent or marginalised?

Which textual choices make an unequal arrangement appear normal or legitimate?

What institutional or social evidence would connect that language to power and inequality? How would you avoid claiming more than the evidence supports?

Support your answers with a lesson excerpt, then compare the features below.

Core features

Makes power, ideology and inequality explicit analytic concerns.
Connects close textual analysis with institutional and social relations.
Supports critical interpretations with both textual and contextual evidence.

A critical orientation within discourse research. It examines how text and discursive practices legitimise, reproduce or challenge unequal social relations.

Likely output: An argument linking specific textual evidence, discursive practices and social structures.

▼ **How do I do it?**

Identify the social problem, institutional context and critical framework.

Analyse textual choices and how texts are produced, circulated and taken up.

Connect the textual evidence to power and inequality; consider alternative interpretations.

Methods reference: Balán (2026) · empirical application of Fairclough's model ↗

Critical discourse analysis · practice and output

▼ Practice text for this lesson

> As a new teacher, I find that balancing my workload is challenging. While I enjoy the creativity involved in lesson planning, the constant demands of grading and administrative tasks often leave me feeling overwhelmed. I sometimes wish I had more support from my colleagues to share ideas and resources. Despite these challenges, seeing my students engage and learn makes it all worthwhile.

Use this short account to practise analytic judgement. Other fictional material in the example tables is labelled separately.

▼ What can an output look like?

A fictional policy calling learners “future workforce assets” could position education around productivity. Examine who gains authority and which educational purposes are absent.

Fictional policy illustration · trace a critical argument

Wording	Representation	Critical question
“future workforce assets”	Learners framed as economic resources	Which educational purposes are privileged?
“every learner must remain competitive”	Obligation placed on individuals	How is responsibility distributed?

Use the illustration to practise analytic judgement. Connect actual claims to the full material and its context.

▼ Empirical study example

Balán (2026) · *The “skills-first” illusion* ↗

A corpus of 15 Microsoft AI-skilling communications is examined through Fairclough’s critical discourse approach, connecting textual choices with discourse and social context.

Using this study summary, explain how the material and analytic decisions fit the method. What further evidence would help you assess the interpretation?

Methods reference: Balán (2026) · empirical application of Fairclough’s model ↗

Grounded theory

Discuss these questions first

What action or process could you investigate in the account? How might one action lead to another?

What would you compare next, and whom would you sample to clarify an emerging category?

What relationships between categories would explain the process? What evidence would make you revise that explanation?

Support your answers with a lesson excerpt, then compare the features below.

Core features

Develops an explanatory theory of a process through iterative analysis and data collection.
Uses constant comparison, analytic memos and theoretical sampling to develop categories and their relationships.
States the grounded-theory tradition and follows its analytic logic.

A methodology for building theory through iterative collection and analysis. Constant comparison, memo writing and theoretical sampling develop relationships between categories.

Likely output: A substantive theory or process model with evidence for relationships between categories.

▼ **How do I do it?**

Compare incidents and develop analytic codes while collecting data.

Write memos about categories, their properties and relationships; let these guide further sampling.

Integrate the categories into an explanatory theory and examine its adequacy.

Grounded-theory traditions use different coding language: constructivist work often uses initial and focused coding; Straussian work can use open, axial and selective coding. State the approach you follow.

Methods reference: Charmaz · Constructing Grounded Theory ↗

Grounded theory · practice and output

▼ Practice text for this lesson

> As a new teacher, I find that balancing my workload is challenging. While I enjoy the creativity involved in lesson planning, the constant demands of grading and administrative tasks often leave me feeling overwhelmed. I sometimes wish I had more support from my colleagues to share ideas and resources. Despite these challenges, seeing my students engage and learn makes it all worthwhile.

Use this short account to practise analytic judgement. Other fictional material in the example tables is labelled separately.

▼ What can an output look like?

The teacher practice text could suggest an initial question about sustaining commitment under workload pressure. A theory would require iterative data collection and comparison.

Fictional illustration · proposed relationships to test

Condition	Action / interaction	Proposed consequence
Work demands intensify	Seeking collegial support	Accessing workable routines
Usable guidance becomes available	Trying and adapting routines	Sustaining participation
Support remains inaccessible	Continuing alone	Prolonged strain

Use the illustration to practise analytic judgement. Connect actual claims to the full material and its context.

▼ Empirical study example

Brown, Howard & Walsh (2022) · *Building Trauma Informed Teachers* ↗

23 interviews and a theoretical-sampling focus group with seven interviewees. Notice that analysis informs further sampling, supporting category development and an explanatory theory.

Using this study summary, explain how the material and analytic decisions fit the method. What further evidence would help you assess the interpretation?

Methods reference: Charmaz · Constructing Grounded Theory ↗

Method selection · compare your reasoning

Case 1: Discourse analysis

The aim is to examine how language constructs roles and power relations; listing policy topics would miss this work.

Case 2: Interpretative phenomenological analysis (IPA)

IPA attends to each person's meaning-making in a significant lived experience, retaining individual differences before cross-case comparison.

Case 3: Qualitative content analysis

Content analysis classifies meaningful content systematically. The intended output is a category system with clear definitions and examples.

Case 4: Grounded theory

Grounded theory develops relationships between categories into an explanatory theory; ongoing analysis guides what data to seek next.

Case 5: Thematic analysis

Thematic analysis develops patterns of shared meaning around central organising ideas. A theme explains a pattern through a central organising idea.

Method selection · compare your reasoning

Case 6: Framework analysis

Framework analysis uses a case-by-issue matrix to support systematic comparisons while retaining each case's context.

Case 7: Narrative analysis

Narrative analysis examines how a story is organised and told over time. Isolating quotations into topics could lose its sequence and plot.

Case 8: Thematic analysis

The aim is to interpret shared meanings across accounts. Thematic analysis can connect these meanings without requiring a new process theory.

Case 9: Critical discourse analysis

Critical discourse analysis makes power and inequality an explicit focus, linking textual evidence to institutional relations.

Case 10: Narrative analysis

The unit of attention is the whole narrated journey and its telling. Studying personal experience alone does not automatically make an analysis IPA.